

Five Key Concerns on AI

Accelerationist vs. Doomer perspectives

Handout for discussion; summaries are concise and paired with sources for factchecking.

1. AI and the Future

Accelerationist view: Accelerationists argue that faster AI development could unlock scientific discovery, better health care, lower-cost services, and broader prosperity if society keeps building and adapting.^[1,2]

Doomer view: Doomers counter that capability gains may outrun safety, governance, and human control; in their strongest form, they warn that advanced AI could create systemic or even existential risk.^[1,2]

2. AI and Jobs

Accelerationist view: Accelerationists see AI mainly as a tool that augments workers, helps less-experienced employees learn faster, and creates new categories of work even as old tasks change.^[3,4]

Doomer view: Doomers emphasize disruption: clerical, routine, and some entry-level knowledge jobs may be displaced first, and transition costs can be severe even if productivity rises overall.^[3,4]

3. AI and the Economy

Accelerationist view: Accelerationists expect AI to raise productivity, lower costs, and support faster growth as adoption spreads through firms and public services.^[5,6,7]

Doomer view: Doomers worry that the gains may be unevenly distributed, reinforcing concentration of wealth, market power, and financial risk if investment outruns real economic value.^[5,6,7]

4. AI and the Environment

Accelerationist view: Accelerationists note that AI can help optimize electric grids, accelerate materials discovery, and improve climate and energy analysis, potentially supporting the clean-energy transition.^[8,9,10]

Doomer view: Doomers point to AI's own footprint: electricity demand from data centers is rising quickly, and research shows growing energy, carbon, and water impacts unless efficiency and cleaner power keep pace.^[8,9,10]

5. AI and Democracy

Accelerationist view: Accelerationists say AI can improve translation, accessibility, and public service delivery while helping citizens find information and participate more easily in civic life.^[11,12,13]

Doomer view: Doomers focus on manipulation risks - deepfakes, cheap disinformation, microtargeting, and surveillance can erode trust, distort elections, and weaken already-fragile democratic institutions.^[11,12,13]

How to use this handout

These summaries contrast two broad camps. Most experts fall somewhere in between: optimistic about useful applications, but supportive of guardrails, transparency, and careful governance.

Footnotes and sources

[1] Marc Andreessen, "The Techno-Optimist Manifesto" (a16z, 2023). <https://a16z.com/the-techno-optimist-manifesto/>

[2] Center for AI Safety, "Statement on AI Risk" (2023). <https://aistatement.com/>

[3] IMF, "Gen-AI: Artificial Intelligence and the Future of Work" (2024). <https://www.imf.org/en/publications/staff-discussion-notes/issues/2024/01/14/gen-ai-artificial-intelligence-and-the-future-of-work-542379>

[4] NBER, Brynjolfsson, Li, and Raymond, "Generative AI at Work" (Working Paper 31161, 2023). <https://www.nber.org/papers/w31161>

[5] Goldman Sachs Research, "Generative AI could raise global GDP by 7%" (2023). <https://www.goldmansachs.com/insights/articles/generative-ai-could-raise-global-gdp-by-7-percent>

[6] OECD, "AI use by individuals surges across the OECD as adoption by firms continues to expand" (2026). <https://www.oecd.org/en/about/news/announcements/2026/01/ai-use-by-individuals-surges-across-the-oecd-as-adoption-by-firms-continues-to-expand.html>

- [7] IMF, “AI Can Lift Global Growth” (Finance & Development, 2026). <https://www.imf.org/en/publications/fandd/issues/2026/03/point-of-view-ai-can-lift-global-growth-marcello-estevao>
- [8] IEA, “Energy and AI - Executive Summary” (2026). <https://www.iea.org/reports/energy-and-ai/executive-summary>
- [9] Nature Sustainability, Xiao et al., “Environmental impact and net-zero pathways for AI servers” (2025). <https://www.nature.com/articles/s41893-025-01681-y>
- [10] Nature Reviews Clean Technology, Stern et al., “Green and intelligent: the role of AI in the climate transition” (2025). <https://www.nature.com/articles/s44168-025-00252-3>
- [11] UNESCO, “Artificial intelligence and democracy” (2024). <https://www.unesco.org/en/articles/artificial-intelligence-and-democracy>
- [12] Brookings, “When it comes to understanding AI’s impact on elections, we’re still working in the dark” (2025). <https://www.brookings.edu/articles/when-it-comes-to-understanding-ais-impact-on-elections-were-still-working-in-the-dark/>
- [13] UNESCO/UNDP, “Impacts of AI on Freedom of Expression and Elections” (2025). <https://www.unesco.org/en/articles/new-unesco-undp-issue-brief-highlights-impacts-ai-freedom-expression-and-elections>